invitation and landed on the tarmac of Havana airport, the Cuban situation had changed dramatically. The American media were suggesting that U Thant was going to Cuba to convince Castro to accept the inspections agreed upon by Kennedy and Khrushchev. The secretary general announced that he was open to discussing a broad range of issues but never contradicted media reports about inspections being one of the main goals of his visit. Indeed they were.[19]

U Thant raised the question of inspections during his very first meeting with Castro on the afternoon of October 30. He laid out the American proposal for inspections without directly associating himself with it. The Cuban leader showed no inclination to change his position on the issue. "What we do not understand is precisely why this is asked of us. We have not violated any law.… To the contrary, we have been the victims, in the first place, of a blockade, which is an illegal act. And secondly, we have been victims of another country's claim to determine what we have the right to do or not to do within our own borders. It is our understanding that Cuba is a sovereign state, no more and no less than any other member state of the United Nations.… As I see it, all this talk about inspection is one more attempt to humiliate our country. We do not accept it."

When U Thant tried to counter his host's national sovereignty argument by citing the example of the government of the Congo, which had invited UN personnel into its territory, the infuriated Castro shot back: "In the Congo the government that made that request is now dead and buried!" The reference was to the former prime minister of the Republic of the Congo, Patrice Lumumba, who was killed in January 1961 by his Western-backed opponents despite the presence of UN troops in the country. Castro refused to accommodate U Thant's request for the inspection not only of missile sites but also of Soviet ships taking weapons back to the USSR as long as they were in Cuban ports. The meeting, in which Castro kept talking about national sovereignty and humiliation and U Thant about the threat to international peace, ended without agreement.[20]

When U Thant and Castro met the next day, the secretary general tried a different tactic. Instead of presenting the American proposal, he gently put forward the Soviet one. He asked Castro what he thought of Khrushchev's letter accepting Kennedy's proposal for UN inspection of missile sites on